

Women's Suffrage and the 19th Amendment

Weigh what changed, what changed slowly, and what stayed the same across the long fight for women's suffrage — and judge whether the 19th Amendment was a true turning point.

? Historical challenge

In 1920, the 19th Amendment declared that the right to vote could not be denied 'on account of sex.' But the amendment capped a 70-year struggle — and it did not give every woman the vote in practice. Compare before, during, and after, then judge: was the 19th Amendment a genuine turning point in American democracy, or a partial victory that left major exclusions in place?

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

19th Amendment to the U.S. Constitution (1920) – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The amendment barring denial of the vote 'on account of sex.'

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What exactly does the amendment say?
- What does it not address?

SOURCES 2

Overview of the Nineteenth Amendment – Constitution Annotated (Library of Congress)

SECONDARY SOURCE

The amendment's text and legal grounding.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How is the amendment's power described legally?
- What questions does it leave open?

SOURCES 3

African American Women and the Nineteenth Amendment – National Park Service

SECONDARY SOURCE

How Black women were often blocked from voting after 1920.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Who was still barred from voting after 1920?
- When did that begin to change?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

THE EVENT

Women's Suffrage and the 19th Amendment

1848–1920

The United States

Before

Women were largely denied the vote nationwide and excluded from most political power.

Under coverture, a married woman's legal identity was subsumed under her husband's.

A few early gains appeared at the state and territory level (Wyoming granted women the vote in 1869).

During

Decades of organizing, petitioning, lecturing, and lobbying through NAWSA and other groups.

Mass suffrage parades and marches, such as the 1913 procession in Washington.

The National Woman's Party picketed the White House ('Silent Sentinels'), and members were arrested and went on hunger strikes.

Women's large-scale contributions during World War I strengthened the argument that they had earned full citizenship.

After

The 19th Amendment was ratified in 1920; sex could no longer be used to deny the vote.

Women began voting in national elections across the country.

Many women of color — especially Black women in the South — remained effectively barred by poll taxes, literacy tests, and intimidation until the Voting Rights Act of 1965.

Changed significantly

Changed gradually

Stayed mostly the same

The constitutional and legal barrier of sex was removed nationwide, and the formal electorate of women roughly doubled.

Suffrage spread state by state over 70+ years, and real voting access for women of color expanded slowly, culminating in 1965.

Racial disenfranchisement persisted, and women remained underrepresented in elected office and political leadership for decades.

Was this event truly a turning point? Use evidence from at least two sources.

Which factor best explains why change happened when and how it did — sustained organizing, shifting public opinion after World War I, or state-level momentum forcing federal action? Cite evidence.

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your ledgers with a partner. Did you sort the same items into 'changed' vs. 'stayed the same'?
- Where did you disagree about whether something changed a lot, a little, or not at all?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

The 19th Amendment (1920) removed sex as a barrier to voting nationwide — a decisive legal change capping 70+ years of organizing from Seneca Falls (1848) forward. But de jure change and de facto access differ: many women of color, especially Black women in the South, remained barred by poll taxes, literacy tests, and intimidation until the Voting Rights Act of 1965. The continuity-and-change lens surfaces both the breakthrough and its limits.

Common misconceptions

- The 19th Amendment did not enfranchise all women in practice — racial barriers persisted until 1965.
- Suffrage was won over 70+ years and state by state, not in a single moment.
- The movement used many tactics — from lobbying and litigation to parades, picketing, and civil disobedience.

Vocabulary

suffrage, ratification, coverture, NAWSA, National Woman's Party, de jure, de facto, disenfranchisement.

Historical context

Seneca Falls 1848; Wyoming 1869; 1913 Washington parade; NWP picketing 1917; Congress passes the amendment June 4, 1919; ratified Aug. 18, 1920; full access for many women of color awaited the Voting Rights Act of 1965.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Was the 19th Amendment a genuine turning point in American democracy, or a partial victory that left major exclusions in place? Use evidence from at least two sources — including at least one that addresses who could actually vote after 1920.